



Pitching for Investment

If you need to borrow to finance your start-up, you will have to persuade funders that your business is a good investment. Thorough preparation is key; be enthusiastic but also honest and realistic.

Preparing to pitch

Once you have identified potential investors, you will need to create a presentation—or pitch—to persuade them to back your business.

Research your potential investors' interests and current investments, and see if they match your plans. Make sure you can describe every aspect of your business, including your customers and competitors. You will also need to show a detailed grasp of finances, so have financial projections to hand, including expected turnover and profits in the short to long term.

Start your pitch with a short, engaging summary of what makes you and your business stand out from the crowd. This is known as an “elevator pitch”—deliverable in the time it takes to ride in a lift. Then describe what the business provides, highlighting the problem it aims to solve or customer wish it can fulfil, before moving on to your service or product solution.

The detail should follow. Outline the marketplace, competition, customers, operations, others involved in the business, and finances, using high quality visuals, such as product examples, artwork, or digital presentations. Finally, set out what funds are needed and their exact purpose. Be sure to practise your pitch to get constructive feedback.

Online presentations

Pitching over a video-conferencing platform, such as Zoom or Google Hangouts, poses particular challenges. Practice your pitch using the platform's various functions and prepare for technical issues, such as losing connection while presenting—perhaps by having a colleague ready to take over. You are not in control of your audience's environment, which may be filled with distractions, so get to the point quickly. Since it is harder to read the room, make your presentation more discussion-based, asking questions and engaging, but allow for time delays and the possibility of talking over each other.

Presenting the pitch

Investors are likely to judge a business at least partly by the person making the presentation. Aim to appear confident but not arrogant, and professional without being inflexible and unwilling to listen. Build a rapport by introducing yourself clearly, making eye contact (or looking into the camera if online), and delivering a strong statement of why your business exists and why customers will buy its products or use its services. Watch the audience to ensure they are still engaged, and note points that raise particular interest as these may appear in later questions. Keep in mind the three key questions below, which may decide future investment. End with a statement of what you are looking for and establish what the next steps will be. It is usual to send a follow-up email a few days after a pitch.



What does the business offer?

Your business needs to offer a viable product or service in order to repay any potential investment.

